DULOXETINE

Neuropathic pain

Hepatotoxic with alcohol

CHEMICAL NAME (S)-N-methyl-3-(naphthalen-1-yloxy)-3-(thiophen-2-yl)propan-1-amine (hydrochloride)

CLASS Serotonin–noradrenaline reuptake inhibitor (SNRI)

TRADE NAMES Cymbalta · Yentreve (stress incontinence) · Dulane

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Major depression; generalised anxiety disorder.
- Diabetic peripheral neuropathic pain.
- Fibromyalgia, chronic musculoskeletal pain (some countries).
- Stress urinary incontinence (women).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** capsules once daily, swallowed whole (enteric-coated).

DOSAGES

- **Depression:** 60 mg once daily.
- **GAD:** 30–60 mg daily (max 120 mg).
- **Neuropathic pain:** 60 mg daily (max 120 mg).
- **Stress incontinence:** 40 mg twice daily.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 1–4 weeks (pain may improve in 1 week).
- Metabolised by CYP1A2 and 2D6; moderate 2D6 inhibitor.
- **t½:** 12 h.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Check LFTs, alcohol history, BP.
- Assess mood and pain scores.
- Taper on discontinuation.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Balanced **5-HT and noradrenaline reuptake** inhibition → antidepressant and enhanced descending pain inhibition.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Nausea (common), dry mouth, constipation.
- Somnolence, fatigue, dizziness.
- Sweating, ↓ appetite.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Hepatotoxicity (avoid in heavy alcohol use).
- Hypertension; urinary retention.
- Suicidality; serotonin syndrome; hyponatraemia; withdrawal.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Hepatic impairment; severe renal impairment (CrCl <30).
- Uncontrolled hypertension.
- MAOIs; ciprofloxacin, fluvoxamine (CYP1A2 inhibitors).

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Fluvoxamine, ciprofloxacin:** ↑↑ levels; contraindicated.
- **Serotonergic drugs:** serotonin syndrome.
- **Anticoagulants:** bleeding.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Swallow capsules whole.
- Limit alcohol.
- Report yellow skin, dark urine, mood changes.
- Do not stop suddenly.

KEY POINTS

- SNRI for depression and neuropathic pain.
- Hepatotoxic — avoid with heavy alcohol.
- 60 mg daily.
- Avoid with ciprofloxacin/fluvoxamine.

SOURCES CHECKED **[783]** Duloxetine 20 mg gastro-resistant capsules, hard (UK SmPC) **[784]** Drizalma Sprinkle, oral (US label) **[785]** Duloxetine, oral (US label)

Full references p. 432–457